Night and day you wear out your pen
Writing letters to our enemies?. . .'[58]

On 3 April, the pressure on Shuja was increased still further when the head of the Kabul 'ulema, Mir Haji, the elder brother of the recently killed Mir Masjidi, took up the call for holy war as well, and in his Friday sermons goaded Shuja to lead an Islamic army against the Kafirs. 'The treacherous and hypocrite Mir Haji', as Mohan Lal called him, 'pitched his tent on the way to Jalalabad and sent the criers to proclaim in the city that he was going on a religious war and whoever being Mussalman will not march with him, shall be considered an infidel.'[59] He then set off leading a long procession of 'wild fakirs carrying alam battle standards and Holy Qur'ans and sacred relics from the shrines, chanting prayers in a vast procession, all heading to Jalalabad. It may have been the merest political manipulation,' commented Herati, 'but His Majesty realised that unless he went with them a new revolt would break out in Kabul.'[60]

The situation was now critical. That night Nawab Zaman Khan sent his wife to the palace with a sealed Qur'an to assure Shuja of his fidelity. 'His wife begged the Shah to march fearlessly along with the Barakzais to Jalalabad and said that her husband will promote the cause and stand by His Majesty as a loyal servant. On considering the proclamations made by Mir Haji and having been insisted upon by all the Chiefs to march against Jalalabad, the Shah was obliged finally to send out his tent and consented to proceed with them.'[61]

The royal campaign tent was duly pitched at Siyah Sang on the Jalalabad road. 'I scarcely believe he will ever march,' wrote an anxious Mohan Lal to Jalalabad, 'and if he does he will either be murdered or blinded by the Barakzais.'[62] For one week more the Shah remained within the Bala Hisar, anxiously waiting to hear if General Pollock had yet managed to bring his army up the Khyber. 'It is nearly one month that I have delayed sending troops to Jalalabad,' he wrote in desperation to MacGregor. 'But during this time no letters have been received from you. I know almost nothing of your intentions. If the British troops arrive within the next ten or fifteen days it is well, but the sooner the better. If not what ought to be done? This is not a matter to be trifled with. Whatever you think advisable, write to me plainly that it may be well understood and arrangements made.'